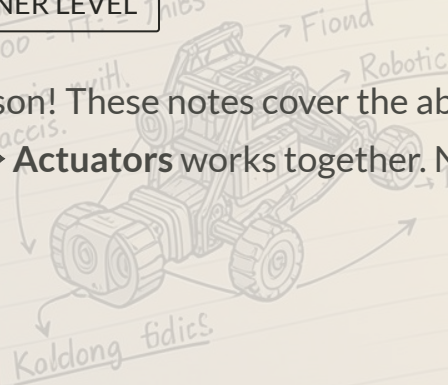


Lesson 01 — Introduction to Robotics

ENGINEERING NOTEBOOK

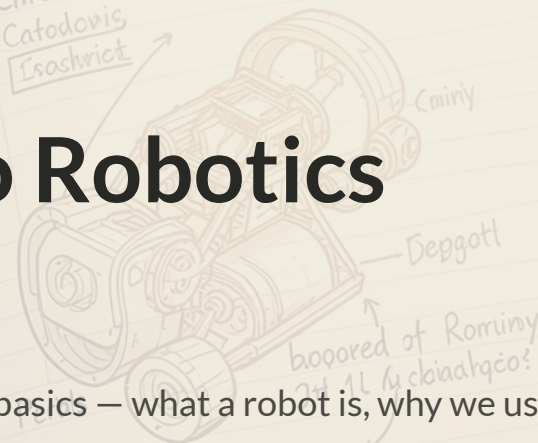
BEGINNER LEVEL

Welcome to your first robotics lesson! These notes cover the absolute basics — what a robot is, why we use them, and how the core system of **Sensors** → **Controller** → **Actuators** works together. No advanced math here, just clear concepts to get you started. 🖍️



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What is a Robot?

A **robot** is a machine that can **sense** its environment, **think** (process information), and **act** on its own — usually under some level of computer control. Robots can be programmed to do tasks automatically, with varying degrees of independence.

The word "**robot**" comes from the Czech word *robota*, meaning "forced labor." The term was first used in a 1920 play by Karel Čapek. Today, robots range from simple toy bots to complex surgical machines!



★ **Key idea:** A robot is NOT just any machine — it must be able to **sense, decide, and act** on its own!

Robotics is the branch of engineering and science that deals with the **design, construction, operation, and application** of robots. It combines mechanical engineering, electronics, and computer science.

Quick Definition

A programmable machine that:

- Senses its surroundings
- Processes information
- Takes physical action
- Can be reprogrammed for new tasks

Why Do We Use Robots?

Robots are used in many fields because they can do things that are **dangerous, repetitive, or too precise** for humans. Here are the main reasons:

Speed & Efficiency

Robots work faster than humans for repetitive tasks — no breaks, no fatigue!

Safety

Handle dangerous jobs like bomb disposal, toxic waste cleanup, or deep-sea exploration.

Precision

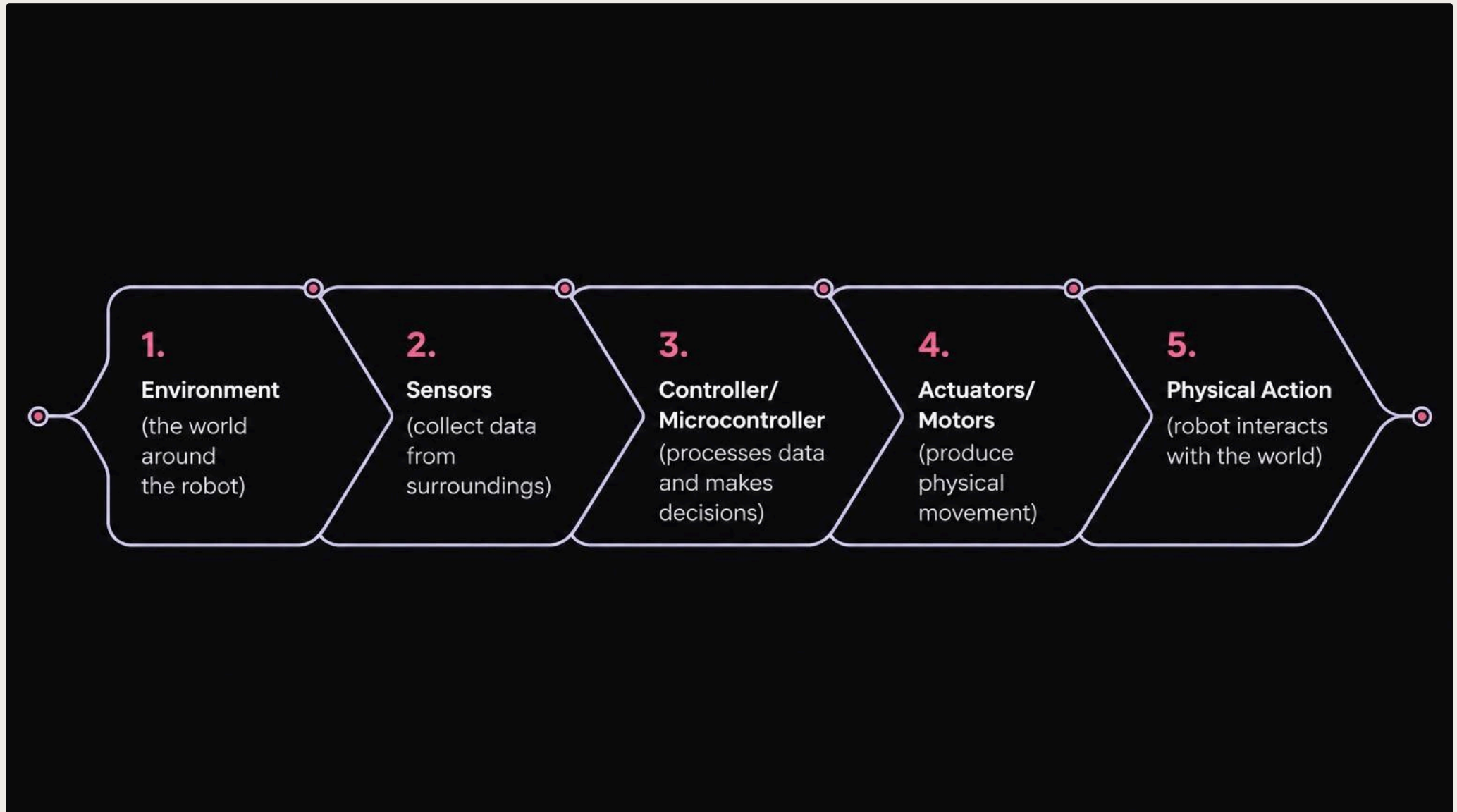
Robotic arms in surgery or manufacturing can achieve accuracy humans simply cannot match.

Repetition

Assembly lines use robots for tasks repeated thousands of times without errors.

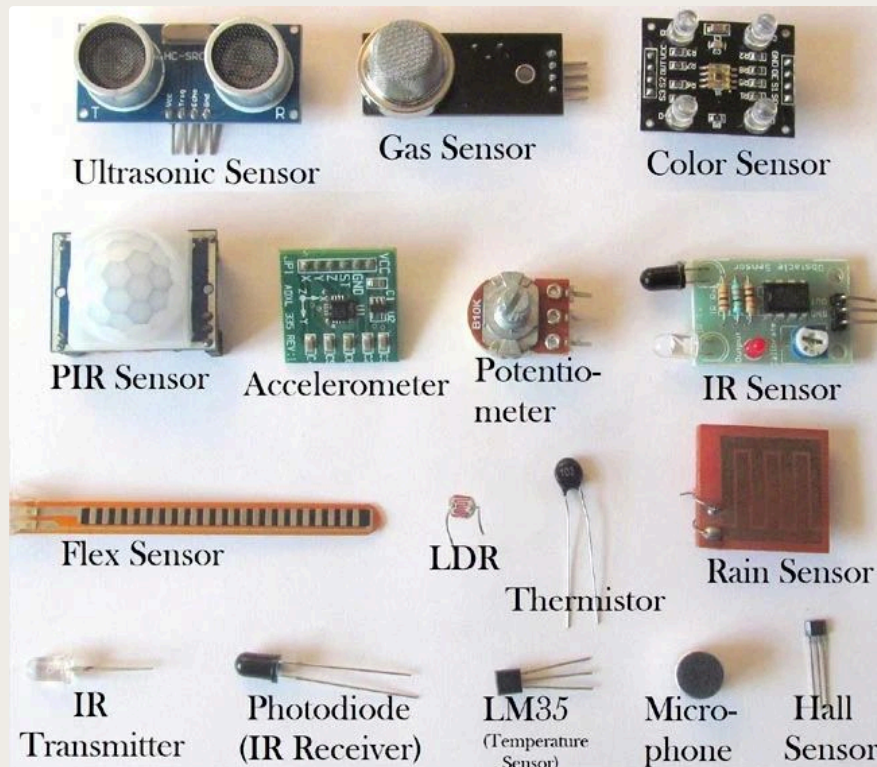
The Robot System – Block Diagram

Every robot, no matter how simple or complex, follows the same basic flow. Think of it as the robot's "nervous system":



The **controller** is the brain — it reads sensor data, runs your program, and sends commands to the actuators. This loop runs continuously while the robot is active! 

Sensors – The Robot's "Eyes & Ears"



Sensors collect information from the robot's surroundings and convert it into electrical signals the controller can understand. Without sensors, a robot is "blind" and "deaf"!

Common Sensor Types:

→ Ultrasonic Sensor

Measures distance using sound waves (like a bat! 🦇)

→ Light / IR Sensor

Detects light intensity or infrared signals

→ Temperature Sensor

Reads ambient or component temperature

→ Touch / Bumper Sensor

Detects physical contact or pressure



Remember: Sensors = **INPUT** to the system. They feed data *into* the controller.

Controller / Microcontroller – The "Brain"

The **controller** (or microcontroller) is the decision-making center of the robot. It reads data from sensors, runs your programmed instructions, and sends commands to actuators. Popular beginner boards include **Arduino** and **ESP32**.

What it does:

- Reads sensor inputs continuously
- Runs your program (the "logic")
- Makes decisions based on conditions
- Sends output signals to actuators

Popular Boards for Beginners:

- **Arduino Uno** – Great starter board, huge community
- **ESP32** – More powerful, has WiFi & Bluetooth built-in
- **Raspberry Pi** – Mini computer, runs full OS

★ Key Point:

The controller is where **your code lives**. You write the logic that tells the robot how to respond to sensor data!

Actuators – The "Muscles" 🦵

Actuators are the components that **produce physical movement or action**. They receive electrical signals from the controller and convert them into motion – this is how the robot actually *does* things in the real world!

Common Actuator Types:

● DC Motor

Spins continuously – used for wheels

● Servo Motor

Rotates to a specific angle – used for arms

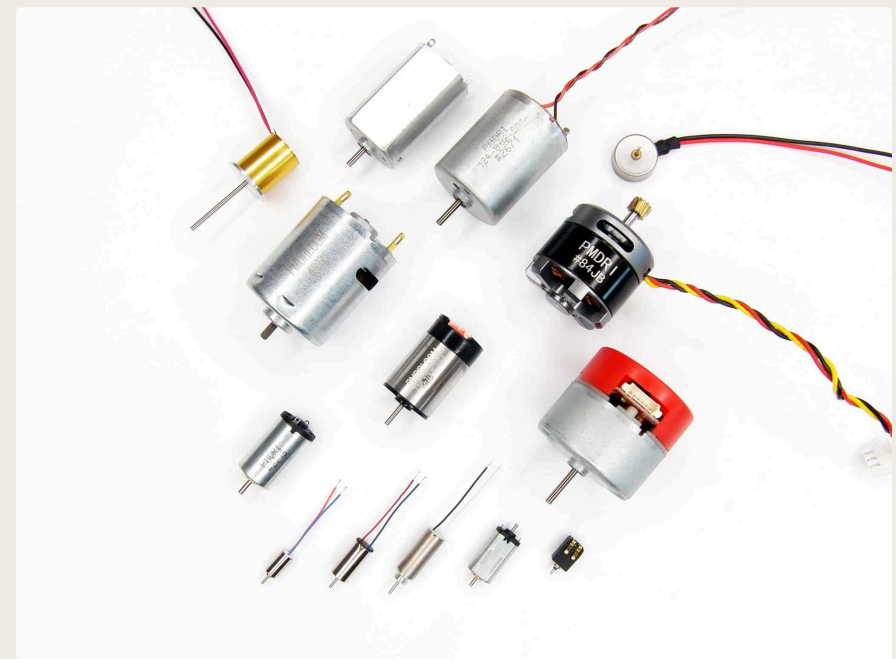
● Stepper Motor

Precise step-by-step rotation

● LED / Buzzer

Simple output – light or sound

📌 ★ **Remember:** Actuators = **OUTPUT** of the system. They are how the robot affects the world!



Power Supply — The "Heart" ❤️

No power = no robot! The **power supply** provides electrical energy to all components. Choosing the right power source is a critical design decision.



Batteries

Portable and convenient. Common types: AA, Li-ion, LiPo. LiPo batteries are popular in drones and RC robots for high energy density.



Solar Panels

Used in outdoor or long-duration robots. Converts sunlight to electricity. Often paired with a rechargeable battery.



Wall Adapter (DC)

Provides steady power from a wall outlet. Good for stationary robots or lab prototypes. Usually 5V or 12V.



Voltage Regulators

Ensure components receive the correct voltage (e.g., 5V for Arduino). Protects sensitive electronics from damage.

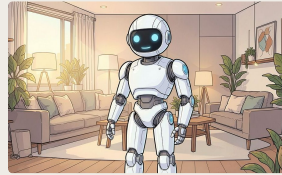
Types & Applications of Robots

Robots come in many shapes and sizes depending on where and how they're used. Here's a quick overview of the major categories:



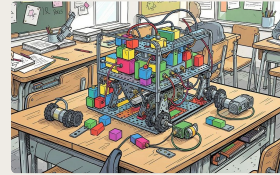
Industrial Robots

Welding, painting, assembly, and packaging in factories.
Examples: robotic arms, CNC machines.



Domestic / Service Robots

Robot vacuum cleaners (Roomba), lawn mowers, and companion robots for home use.



Educational Robots

LEGO Mindstorms, Arduino-based robots, line followers — used to teach STEM concepts.



Medical Robots

Surgical robots (like da Vinci), rehabilitation robots, and drug delivery systems.

Lesson 01 — Summary & Key Takeaways

Here's everything from Lesson 01 at a glance. Review these before moving to Lesson 02!

01

What is a Robot?

A programmable machine that can **sense, decide, and act** on its environment.

02

The Core Loop

Environment → Sensors → Controller → Actuators → Physical Action — this is the heart of every robot!

03

Three Main Components

Sensors (input), **Controller** (brain/decision), **Actuators** (output/movement).

04

Power Supply Matters

Batteries, wall adapters, or solar — every robot needs a reliable power source.

05

Robots Are Everywhere

Industry, medicine, education, homes — robotics is a huge and growing field!



Up Next — Lesson 02: We'll dive into **Arduino basics** — pins, circuits, and your first blink program. Get your board ready!